

The land boundaries remain equally vulnerable. India shares 3,323 km of border with Pakistan, including the disputed Line of Control. Of the total 2,308 km of border that needs to be fenced, about 1,900 km has been done, but only 1,800 km has been floodlit. Only 2,500 km of a 4,000-km porous border with Bangladesh—another infiltration prone area—has been fenced. Votebank politics and a politico-criminal nexus ensures that parts of the borders are never fenced or villagers never

shifted behind the zero line.

Long stretches of borders that India shares with Nepal—1,751 km and Myanmar—1,643 km are still open and vulnerable to infiltration and gun-running. The Border Security Force which has 157 battalions to guard the entire western and eastern borders of over 7,000 km says it is facing a manpower crunch and existing troops are under severe strain. It urgently needs 69 more battalions or at least 69,000 more personnel to plug the gaps (each battalion has 1,000 troopers).

Further inland from the vulnerable coast is India's booming infrastructure that has an eggshell fragility because it never invests in security. Except for the civil aviation sector where the Bureau of Civil Aviation and Security (BCAS) draws up a list of safeguards for airlines and airports, there is no agency in the Government which performs a security evaluation of the private power projects, shopping malls, multiplexes, IT parks and five-star hotels. Since 9/11, the US Department of Homeland Security has made critical infrastructure protection the shared responsibility of the federal, state and local government in active partnership with the private sector which owns approximately 85 per cent of the critical national infrastructure in the US.

This is one gap that needs to be plugged immediately. The Central

Action Plan

BORDER fencing to be completed on priority.

VACANCIES in CISF and BSF to be augmented to enhance border protection and security of public and private infrastructure projects.

MAJOR vital installations to be identified and protected and technology to be used to cut manpower.

SECURITY engineering to be made mandatory for all projects before clearances are issued.

COASTAL Command and Maritime Adviser must liaise with the eight ministries which look after maritime issues.

Industrial Security Force (CISF), for instance, guards most central government central infrastructure including airports and power plants has a force of around one lakh personnel but needs at least 20,000 more personnel to protect vital installations.

The Government needs to empower the CISF to conduct detailed vulnerability assessments of major private sector infrastructure projects and ensure security is integrated into projects from their inception. Wherever possible, technology like surveillance cameras, electronic perimeters and motion detectors can be used to reduce the need for manpower-intensive security. These guidelines could go a long way in preventing future attacks.

Experts' Opinion

A lowdown on what can be done to ensure sound border security

ADMIRAL ARUN PRAKASH



Former chief of naval staff

■ New coastal command should be under the naval commands and must coordinate with other agencies.

■ Marine police force should be set up for shore and inshore patrolling of the coastal areas.

VICE ADMIRAL A. K. SINGH



Former DG, Coast Guard

■ Funding for an Indian Maritime Domain Awareness Grid should be facilitated at the earliest.

■ Hiring retired sailors to man the CISF harbour patrols be considered for augmenting the forces.

SIS AHMED



Former DG, CISF, CRPF

■ Vulnerability assessments for all major private sector as well as public sector projects.

■ Make security engineering mandatory. No permissions be given unless a project is secured.

E.N. RAMMOHAN



Former DG, BSF

■ Seal the Nepal, Bangladesh and Pakistan borders and place them under electronic surveillance.

■ Induct more shallow draught vessels for the coast guard to patrol closer to the shore.